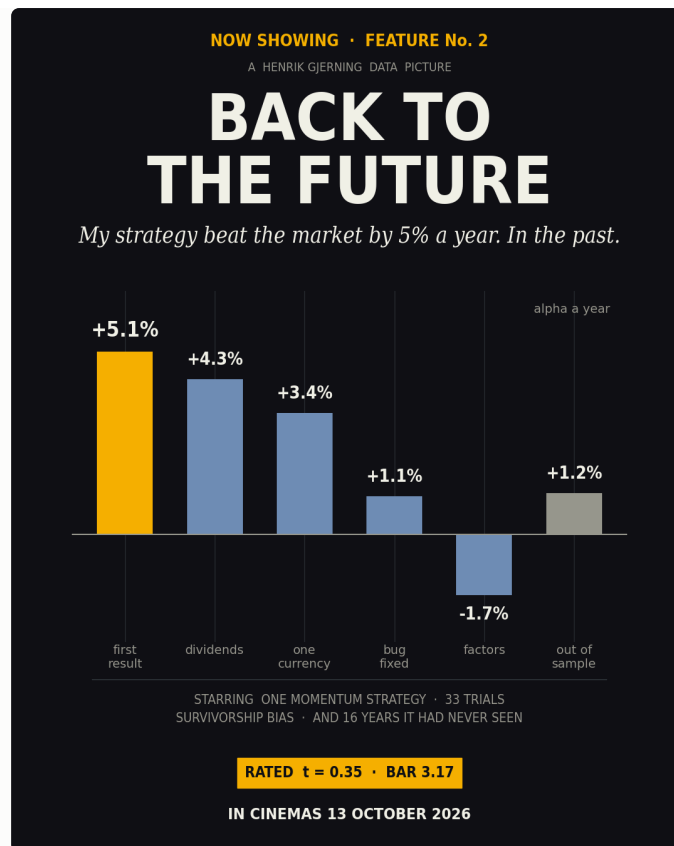




Henrik Gjerner · LinkedIn · 13 October 2026

BACK TO THE FUTURE: my strategy beat the market by 5% a year. In the past.

Then I tested it properly.

In early September I had what every quant hopes for: a momentum strategy with +5.1% a year of alpha against the MSCI World ETF, t -stat 2.90.

Then I checked it, one correction at a time:

- Include dividends everywhere: +4.3%
- Measure every leg in the same currency: +3.4%
- Fix a bug that had quietly turned it into buy-and-hold: +1.1%, t 0.35
- Adjust for known factors: -1.7%

Then the test I wrote down in advance: sixteen years of data it had never seen. Result: +1.2% a year, t 0.24, and a -79% drawdown against the market's -56%.

Two lessons cost the most.

Survivorship: backtesting on today's index members flattered the Sharpe ratio by 20–37% in every region I measured.

The wrong null: 36% of random 10-stock portfolios from the same universe also "beat" the market with $t > 2$.

I tried 33 things along the way, so the honest bar was $t = 3.17$. Nothing cleared it.

One thing survived: skipping small trades added +0.16 to the Sharpe ratio, significant in every region. The only edge I found was trading less.

The total haircut, 79%, is ordinary. Published anomalies lose 58% after publication; bank strategies lose a median 73% once live. The hard part is not beating the market. It is not believing you already have.

